

Grace Versus Works

Are you ready to continue our study on the laws of meditation?

This morning it just kept coming to me. We are going to pick on a real hard subject in a real hard chapter. How about grace versus works?

We will begin in Romans chapter 4, then we will be in 2 Corinthians chapter 8.

In these morning sessions, we have been studying the laws that govern meditation of His Word. We have found out valuable principles to meditation, both morning and night. Our theme verse has been Psalm 1:1, which declared you and me blessed: blessed because we meditate the Word day and night, blessed because we do not have to take our counsel from the world, blessed because we do not have to do things the way sinners do, blessed because we do not sit in the seat of the scornful.

We have been talking on meditation and love because part of being that blessed man is not sitting in the seat of the scornful. Amen.

If we wanted to pattern our teaching abilities, our style, or our learning abilities after anyone, we chose Jesus. We could have been studying after Paul. You do not believe me? We can do it. But we chose to study after Jesus in the form of His parables.

We found out Jesus is the Master Teacher. None of us have any trouble with that. Amen. He is the greatest Teacher who ever lived. He said, "What I hear the Spirit say, that I say; and what I see Him do, that I do."

There is one important basic thing all of us should know, and we have been hammering it in: Jesus always taught in total and entire subjects. He never went on to the next subject until He finished or completed the one He was on.

Again, if He were teaching on this pulpit, He would begin at the top of it using the mastery and imagery of words. By the time He reached the bottom, He would have painted, using words, a perfect picture of this pulpit in your spirit.

That means every verse is a thought within itself. It is a stroke of the brush, but invariably it is always building toward the completion of the entire picture.

How many of you saw that more vividly last night than you probably ever have before, as we broke one of the most difficult verses in the entire Word of God?

This morning, when we get a little further into where we are going, you are going to see the value once again of refusing to take a verse out of context and allowing the Holy Spirit to teach you how to meditate.

Grace versus works this morning. Are you ready?

Beginning with Romans 4:1:

What shall we say then that Abraham our father, as pertaining to the flesh, hath found?
For if Abraham were justified by works, he hath whereof to glory; but not before God.

There is a lot leading up to that statement, "What shall we say then?" We do not have three months. Love it, do you not?

Let us analyze this verse for a moment. If I built the Empire State Building, planned it, plumbed it, and drove every nail, I could glory all right. I could stand back and glory in the feat I accomplished, but I could not glory before God, because it was my works. I am the one who built it. He did not.

So I could glory in it, but I could not glory before God because I did it.

Then he goes on to say:

For what saith the scripture? Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness.
Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt.

Now, I do not want to work then.

Are you talking about your job? No, I am not talking about your job. I am talking about things pertaining to redemption that have been bestowed on us by grace.

To him that works, the reward is not reckoned of grace, but of debt.

What in the world is he talking about here? It could go something like this. Some of you have entered into a program of works and you have not really known that you have done it.

I do not know how many times I have been ready to pray for somebody, knowing they were going to get healed until the anointing lifted, and they said, "If God heals me, my neighbors will be saved. The teenagers who run around with my kids may be saved. If God will just heal me, they will all be born again."

Do you know what you did? You just had to give God a reason. You just had to put Him in debt. You had to give Him several good reasons outside of the fact that He loves you, that He bore your sicknesses, and that He carried your pains.

There is no other way to access that but by faith in His grace, because you could not earn it. You did not deserve it. You did not merit it. Yet He bestowed it on you by an act of the Spirit anyway.

What happens? Because of condemnation, because you never think you are good enough, you begin thinking of reasons and giving Him reasons why He should heal you.

When we enter into a program of works, what God does basically is pay us for what we are worth. Many of you have given in a program of works, so you got paid for what you were worth. You certainly did not like that, did you?

I remember when I went on the radio. It was funny. I expanded so fast, one station after another after another. I remember getting about my third month's bills. My God, I had never seen that much money in my life, much less to pay a radio bill. I had only been full-time one year.

I said, "God, You need me on the radio. These guys are billing me for the second time, and it seems to me You really need me on the radio."

I was telling God about this woman who got delivered from hearing my program. She was demon-possessed, and I did not know the difference. I ran live deliverances over the radio.

"Come out!"

Then there would be screaming and everything. I edited that and put it on. The radio station called me and said there were two things people complained about: running live deliverances, and my singing.

The station manager was so nice. He explained to me, "What if somebody happened to tune in?" The station was half western and half gospel, gospel in the morning and western in the afternoon. He said, "What if they think that was the kind of singing for the radio station?"

The reason was that my editor was just a kid, fourteen or fifteen years old. He edited it up and thought it would be good to run three of my songs in succession.

The manager said, "What if somebody tuned in and three songs like that came on?"

I said, "All right, all right."

Then there were the live deliverances and some of my language he asked me not to use, like "throw up." He said, "Could you use better language, like regurgitation or reverse peristalsis or something?"

Anyway, I was screaming at this devil, saying, "Come out!" Then there would be a blood-curdling scream.

There was a woman in her house having a nervous breakdown, taking a bath. When I started yelling, "Come out," she went crazy. She said something came all over her, she felt weak and nauseated, and felt crazy for a little while. Then she started throwing up all over the place. She said, "I was completely healed. I had no more nerve problems."

I was telling God how much He needed me on the radio, and that the least He could do was pay the bill because they were billing me down here, not Him. I was telling Him all of my good works. Do you think it impressed Him? No. The bills got bigger.

Then, thank God, He began to turn me. When I came before Him and said, "Heavenly Father, by an act of grace, I know that He has borne my sicknesses and carried my pains. But show me in the area of finances: was it an act of grace that He became my poverty and turned around and gave me His standing?"

Then I said, "Heavenly Father, not based on what I am doing or what I have done, I am approaching You simply through the fact that He has become my poverty. My faith is in the fact that He bestowed His standing on me."

Folks, the money started coming. It started coming because I quit being paid for what I was worth and started getting paid for what He was worth.

He said that to the man who works, the reward is reckoned not of grace but of debt. I can think of no other area than giving where the people of God get into grace-versus-works concepts. In the area of giving, there is more works than in any other area bestowed on us by grace.

Since we are studying meditational laws, I thought it would be good to pick hard subjects. Amen.

Go to 2 Corinthians chapter 8. We are heading toward something. I want you to notice verse 1. We will not have time to read every verse, but we will get enough to you as we lead up to verse 9.

Moreover, brethren, we do you to wit of the grace of God bestowed on the churches of Macedonia.

Notice the word "grace" mentioned here. Whatever happened in this church, he called it the grace of God.

Poverty abounded. It abounded into the riches of their liberality. Whatever happened, the church in Macedonia came out of poverty. They came out of absolute poverty because of liberality. But their coming out of poverty, Paul called the grace of God that was bestowed on that church.

Do you notice that? He called it an act of grace that they came out of debt. Is that not tremendous?

Look at verse 6:

Insomuch that we desired Titus, that as he had begun, so he would also finish in you the same grace also.

Once again, he called whatever happened an act of grace.

If that is not enough, the second time the word grace is mentioned, look at verse 7:

Therefore, as ye abound in every thing, in faith, and utterance, and knowledge, and in all diligence, and in your love to us, see that ye abound in this grace also.

My God, he called it a grace again.

If you were meditating this chapter, by now would not his calling this abounding in God "grace" catch your attention? How many of you want to abound in prosperity? We will raise our hands, but we are a little slower to raise them than if I said, "How many of you want to abound in the grace of God?" Then you would all raise your hands.

Yet three times he has called this abounding grace. G-R-A-C-E.

Could it be that some of you are not prospering quite like you should because you do not understand what abounding in that kind of grace means?

Do you know that giving is as much a grace as receiving?

What grace is he talking about? I have abounded in faith, in utterance, and in diligence. Good Lord, this generation is quicker to speak their faith than any other generation before. We are more diligent now to act on the Word of God than any other generation before us. We are abounding in all of that. We are abounding in love, and I thought it good to cover love because I knew he said this.

We are even abounding in love. But then he turned around and said, "See that you abound in this grace also." If he wants me to abound in this grace, then Dave Roberson wants to abound in it.

What grace is he talking about?

Let us go to verse 9:

For ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ...

Stop. "For ye know the grace." This is the grace he is asking you to abound in. Do you know it? That is what he is asking you. "For ye know the grace."

He is going to explain this kind of grace, the grace he is talking about whether or not you know. Do you know this grace?

I know what grace is, at least I know the basic breakdown of grace. I know enough to define grace and mercy. What is the basic meaning of grace? Grace is His unmerited, unearnable favor bestowed on you and me. Anytime in your own thinking you get to thinking you are meriting it, anytime in your own thinking you get to thinking you are earning it, you are wrong.

Grace cannot be earned. It cannot be merited. Grace is a free gift bestowed on you and me and appropriated by faith.

He says, "Do you know this grace?"

Well, do you?

What grace is He talking about? He goes on to explain:

For ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, that ye through his poverty might be rich.

He did it for me. He became poor that you, through the substitution of Himself in your poverty, might be rich. He called this whole thing a grace.

Do you know this grace? Not really, but we are learning.

You know the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He did it for you. He became poor. He substituted Himself in your poverty just like He substituted Himself in your sin, just like He substituted Himself in the chastisement of peace being laid on Him by punishment, and just like He substituted Himself in your sicknesses, your pains, and your diseases.

He substituted Himself in your poverty so He could turn around and give you His standing, whether we believe it or not, which is entirely up to us.

It has been recorded in the annals of heaven that if Dave Roberson never gives one penny to the kingdom of God, if Dave Roberson never receives one penny from the Spirit of God, it is still reported in heaven. Let God be true and every man a liar. He cannot lie.

It was reported in the Spirit two thousand years ago that Jesus Christ took Dave Roberson's poverty and turned around and gave me His standing. If I never appropriate one red penny of that for the gospel's sake by faith in His grace, not one penny, that does not exclude the fact that the transaction took place in the Spirit. His standing has been reported in all the heavenlies as bestowed on you and bestowed on me.

So when He says, "Roberson, do you understand this grace?" not entirely, but I know enough about it to give you the first step.

How are you doing?

What if I go to heaven poor? Then He is going to hug you up, wash your tears away, and say, "Welcome in, child." But it does not exclude the fact that all this other stuff is available. Amen. It does not exclude it.

In fact, how do you think Christians are putting up entire television networks now? Because we are finding out just a few of these concepts, a few of these principles.

This is where my thinking was ruined. If you follow me closely, you can see what the devil did to me in some areas where he may possibly be harassing you.

When I was in ultra, ultra, ultra holiness, they told me continually God was stripping me, breaking me, and keeping me poor because that was humility. Then I found out that humility is teachable, and pride is unteachable. To be humble was not to be poor.

In fact, if you were poor and thought you were humble, then you were unteachable because He was trying to get something else to you. You were poor and proud of it, were you not? If I thought it was God who did it to me, I was proud of it. "Oh, He knows. He knows." I was very poor and very humble.

The first thing God delivered me from was deception. Then came the revelation that He wanted me to prosper because Jesus did take my poverty. The second thing He delivered me from was my program of works. Even though I already knew this, I was still trying to earn the standing that Jesus had bestowed on me by faith.

With myself, I finally got to the place where I accepted the fact that I was the righteousness of God in Christ. Oh, that was the dawning of a new day. I pulled myself together and knew I would never be beaten past a certain point anymore, because I am the righteousness of God in Christ.

Then I realized that by an act of grace He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains, and I could not earn that. I was simply to accept it and rejoice in it, because I did not merit it or earn it, and He gave it to me. I learned how to accept it in the Spirit, and it started manifesting in my body.

But in the area of giving, it was giving me a harder time. Even when I found out I was righteous, I still had some of that worm, low, no-good condemnation complex hanging on me. All our songs were born out of that: "Give me a cabin in the corner of glory land." Where do you think that consciousness came from? "I am a worm. I am low. I am no good."

For me to find out He was made to be my sin, and not by my works, that I was absolutely declared the righteousness of God. I had been heading for hell as fast as I could go, so I had absolutely no access to God whatsoever. But Jesus Christ stepped into my shoes for the sole purpose of taking every damnable thing I had coming. Now I have access to that which was inaccessible, not by my works, but by His grace.

In a nutshell, unless I keep wallowing about this, I cannot let you know enough how free I feel. You would have had to stand in my shoes to stand here and just be able to say, "I am righteous." That is a major feat in the spirit world in itself.

Glory. Do you think I would stop with that? I would not stop with that. I went right on into healing and then right on into prosperity by the grace of God.

When I found out it was not by my works, but that by an act of grace He became my poverty, I also found out I cannot access this any other way but faith. When I give, my giving must be in faith. It must be in faith in the fact that He became my poverty, for I cannot access grace any other way.

When I started finding these things out, I wanted to know more about it. I wanted to know more about it from the Master Teacher Himself, Jesus Christ. It did not amaze me anymore when He opened it up and started showing me.

Go to Matthew 19. I wanted it from Jesus, and He gave it to me.

Let us begin at verse 18. You will have to hold fast, because I have been exhorting up to this time, and now come some progressive laws once again. No verse out of context.

I wanted to know from Jesus, from His teachings, where by an act of grace, not by my works, He bestowed His standing on me. I wanted to know, "Jesus, from Your teachings, show me that I cannot earn it. Show me that it does not matter how long I work, one hour or fifteen, that my reward is not reckoned of debt but by grace. In other words, if I can believe everything Jesus said, then it is accessible by faith."

If you are wondering whether I ceased from my works, are you kidding? I worked more abundantly than ever. The difference was that my works were crucified at the cross, and my giving was not based on law, fear, or commandment. It was based on grace.

Are you ready to begin this?

He saith unto him, Which? Jesus said, Thou shalt do no murder, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness,
Honour thy father and thy mother: and, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.
The young man saith unto him, All these things have I kept from my youth up: what lack I yet?

You know, if you have ever meditated on this chapter, that a rich young ruler came to Jesus and said, "What must I do to inherit eternal life?" Jesus said, "Keep these commandments," and He named these. The last one He named was, "Love thy neighbor as thyself."

The young man said to Him, "All these things have I kept from my youth up. What do I lack yet?"

Without Jesus just flat telling him, "There is one commandment here you have not kept from your youth up," Jesus demonstrated it to him.

He said, "You lack one thing yet. If you want to be perfect, if you want to be mature, if you want to go all the way with God, go and sell what you have and give to the poor. You shall have treasure in heaven, and come and follow Me."

Notice the rich young ruler's reaction:

But when the young man heard that saying, he went away sorrowful: for he had great possessions.

Without Jesus just telling him, "You are not loving your neighbor as yourself," He told him to sell what he had and give it to the poor. The man could not do it, and it caused him to become exceedingly sorrowful.

Had the man possessed the capacity to love his neighbor as himself, he would have loved his neighbor as much as he loved himself. Would it not have been within his capacity to sell all he had and give it to his neighbor? Without Jesus just telling him he was not operating in that, He gave him the commandment: "Go do this." And he could not.

Do you realize what this man turned down when Jesus said, "Follow Me"? He meant follow Him as one of the disciples. He did not invite everyone He ran into in every crowd to follow Him. I believe that rich young ruler was a choice to replace Judas. What a place in eternity to hold, and he turned it down over some filthy lucre.

Can you imagine that?

In my meditations when I was here, I thought, "My God, in my history, Heavenly Father, what have I turned down every time I have bowed my head in Your presence?" It almost made me want to cry.

The rich young ruler wanted to follow Jesus, all right, just like many of you want to do feats for God. And it made him very, very sorrowful.

What caught my interest here in these meditations was this: once again, I rolled over it so many times that I was there. All the disciples were standing around Jesus, and they watched Him handle this rich young ruler. They watched him walk away exceedingly sorrowful.

Can you imagine how they felt? They were not exactly a poor lot. Peter had a fishing franchise. He supplied fish and chips. Do you think he ate all of it? He had a fishing franchise. Matthew was a tax collector. Have you ever seen a poor one? Matthew was not poor.

When Jesus said to the rich young ruler, "Give all that you have, and come and follow Me," Peter probably looked into Matthew's eyes, and his eyes were this big as they watched the man go over the mountain. Then Jesus turned around and looked at them, and I can just imagine them fidgeting and hiding behind Bartholomew and the rest of them.

"Do not look at me. Do not look at me."

Knowing in the Spirit what was going on, I wanted to find out how He handled them. Would you not?

Look at verse 23:

Then said Jesus unto his disciples, Verily I say unto you, That a rich man shall hardly enter into the kingdom of heaven.

And again I say unto you, It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God.

Now notice their reaction:

When his disciples heard it, they were exceedingly amazed, saying, Who then can be saved?

They were exceedingly amazed and said, "My God, man, then who can possibly be saved?"

After they reacted the way they did, I knew He said what He said. So I said, "Lord, what is this? How hardly shall a rich man enter the kingdom of heaven? What kind of statement is this? It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven."

This saying exceedingly amazed them to the degree that they turned around and started talking among themselves, saying, "What is the use? Who can possibly be saved?" Brother, that is a dilemma.

What Jesus says to them from now on is critical, because He answers their question thoroughly. I will prove it to you as the laws of meditation progress.

Do not think I did not get my Greek books out. I did not want to be in the rich young ruler's shoes. I got my Greek interlinear, my outer linear, my exterior, my interior, my Wuest and Strong's. I got everything I could find on the eye of the needle and the camel going through it.

To my horror, shock, and amazement, the Greek was talking about a camel. To my shock, horror, and amazement, the eye of the needle was actually talking, in the Greek rendering, about the eye of a sewing needle like Luke would use if he sewed you up.

God visited me in my dilemma. A man brought me a historical book. He said, "Have you ever seen one of these?" I had studied historical books before, but this one was on customs. Whenever there was a certain custom, like the wedding ceremony and different things like that, you could explore those customs and words that had customs connected with them. It was a tremendous book.

I was thumbing through it, and that parable, that certain teaching, came back to me. Immediately I went to find out what that phrase meant, because "a camel going through the eye of a needle" was used quite frequently in that day.

I found out that the reason they called it the eye of the needle, patterned after a sewing needle, was because there was an outside gate that opened into the entire road that took all the traffic into Jerusalem. But when they closed the main gate, there was an inner gate. This inner gate was called a security gate. The guards stood by it, and men would come and knock on it. Then they would open it up.

This security gate was in the exact shape of the eye of a needle, so that is why they nicknamed it that. When a traveler came along with a camel, his camel would be laden down with bags, money bags, and merchant treasures. But for security reasons, that camel would not fit through the eye of the needle because it was shaped in the exact form of the hump of his back. They could not carry any weapons or anything else across.

They would make the traveler completely unload the camel. Then the camel actually had to get on its knees and squeeze through the eye of the needle. It would not fit through with any excess baggage on its back.

This is the imagery He put forth. Jesus said, "It is easier for that camel to get rid of all of its goods and enter the kingdom of heaven than it would be for a rich man."

When I started seeing this, my spirit started coming alive, and revelation knowledge began to flow again. I knew that eye of the needle was a type of the kingdom of God that you and I entered when we passed from death to life through the rebirth.

Follow me closely.

Look at the dilemma it placed these disciples in:

When his disciples heard it, they were exceedingly amazed, saying, Who then can be saved? But Jesus beheld them, and said unto them, With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.

The breakdown on "Jesus beheld them" is that He actually looked on them with love because of the dilemma they had been placed in. He looked on them with love and said, "With men this is impossible. But with God all things are possible."

When I was still in my dilemma, I went to those who seemed to be somewhat among them. I said, "What does that mean? With men it is absolutely impossible to enter the kingdom of God with your wealth, but with God it is possible. What does that mean?"

They said, "Well, once you are born again, God will work on your nature and change your nature until you can have money."

Of course, they do not have any. That is a fruit of what the verse is saying, but it would not quite ring true in context with me.

I said, "What do You mean, with God it is possible? With men it is impossible. Is it because He changes my nature? What are You talking about here, Father?"

It finally dawned on me: "Do you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet in substitution He, as God, took your place?"

With men it is impossible, but with God all things are possible. He laid down all of His heavenly treasures, all of His wealth, and went through the eye of the needle, which is spiritual death, into the kingdom of God in your place as your substitute.

When it was impossible for you to squeeze through the eye of the needle with your wealth, Jesus laid all of His heavenly treasures down as your substitute and went through the eye of the needle in your place. When He emerged on the other side, He picked up all of His heavenly wealth, and

what you could not do, He bestowed in the form of a hundredfold on you by an act of grace because you could not do it.

He went through the eye of the needle in my place. What was impossible with Dave Roberson was possible with God, because the only One qualified to carry my poverty laid all His treasures aside and went through the eye of the needle in my place. When He emerged on the other side, He gave me a hundredfold. One hundredfold is the number of perfection, meaning He gave me all that He had.

I want you to notice the reaction of the disciples. Peter sticks his mouth in here again. Peter has something to say about everything, so he became the spokesman of the crowd, he and his fishing franchise. He just wanted to make sure.

Peter said what we are too humble to ask. But if we are too humble to ask this question, the least you and I can do is get in on the answer.

Then answered Peter and said unto him, Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore?

"We left everything to follow You. What are we going to get out of it?"

Since we are too humble to ask that question, at least do not be too humble to get in on the answer. You ought to thank God for a loudmouth like Peter. He voiced everything.

"Look, the tree You cursed has withered away."

"We fished all night and did not get anything. Everybody knows nighttime is the best time to fish. Nevertheless, at Thy word..." That was not a faith statement. He meant, "If we do not get anything now, we are going to blame it on You. You are the One who said it."

Peter had something to say about it, and this time was no different. If he was going to lose his fishing franchise, he wanted to know what he was going to get out of it.

I knew Jesus was going to answer him, because I was kind of curious myself, although I am much too humble to ask.

And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me...

That is actually two thoughts:

...that in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.

I thought, "That is real good for Peter and the other eleven. How about us spiritual-seed Gentiles?"

Thank God the next one says:

And every one...

I did not want to appear too obvious, but I was interested in the answer.

And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name's sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

Another place says he shall receive a hundredfold in this life, and shall inherit everlasting life.

But then He says:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

Hang on a minute. Everyone who has forsaken houses, mother, brother, or lands, He said, in this lifetime, in this life, will receive one hundredfold.

The problem with this statement is that I can count on two hands the men who operate in God that I would have considered as receiving a hundredfold in this area. I said, "Lord, is this thing so hidden from Joe Public and Susie Q that we are missing it? Why can You make such a bold statement, yet we can count on two hands the men and women who have been there, who have actually claimed that it was an operation of the grace of God in their life?"

God, it was through giving, but they received a hundredfold, and they are what they are. You can count them on two hands.

I said, "Lord, this thing should not be so hidden from us. We want to take the world. I know that a man's life does not consist in the abundance of the things he has. This is not a temporary operation. It never has been. It never will be. It is an eternal operation. What You were trying to say is that prosperity is the fruit of an eternal operation. If it is not, then your life does not consist of those things. It consists of what you are in Jesus Christ."

I said, "How are we missing it?"

I hear preachers jumping up and preaching all the time, "Give, and it shall be given unto you, pressed down, shaken together, and running over." I have seen them take calculators and break the hundredfold down. Brother, by the time they were done, they had us giving five dollars and having a phenomenal amount come back.

After all that teaching to excite me about giving, after hundreds of giving-excited receiving seminars on how to receive from God, I gave and gave and lifted my face heavenward and waited for the return. The only thing I received was the same increases in my paychecks that the sinners got. That was the same time those were supposed to come.

Whenever I got into a crisis and prayed, "Oh God, deliver me," He came on the scene and delivered me because I threw myself on His grace. But every time I tried to merit anything by my goodness, I ended up in failure.

I can remember in the days when I made my mind up that to be poor was humble. God knows how much I loved Him, and the call of God was so heavy on me that at night sometimes I would go out into the woods frustrated because nobody could tell me how to enter in. I remember beating those pine trees with a baseball bat and praying and crying. I wanted to go full-time but was afraid to death my family would starve.

So I had no confidence in God in that area.

Even though I earned \$160 a week, every two weeks I would take home my pay from the mill. My wife and I tithed the sixty. We kept a hundred and had three little kids. She wore one maternity blouse through two pregnancies. We went out after the machines and gleaned potatoes out of the field. We stuck them under our house in gunny sacks because I could only buy enough food to last one week. Then I would eat toast and fried potatoes until the following payday.

Most of the time the revivals only came within a hundred miles of our town. We would take a hundred dollars. We would give out of that, buy groceries, and try to outfit the kids.

I gave to God then because I loved Him, hoping that someday when I went full-time He would give it all back.

When I first went full-time, I spent the first three months praying in tongues, and it brought the Word of God to me by a God-appointed teacher, Kenneth Hagin. Then came the mysteries and revelation knowledge that began to flow and turned me around. In one year He gave me a brand-new motor home, two new cars, and another house. When I moved out of that two-story house, He gave me a brand-new house.

I have had three houses since I lived in Tulsa four years, and three airplanes. The other day a lady gave me a boat, a 27-foot boat that sleeps six. It has not even seen water yet.

You say, "Why?"

Because finally I have entered into a love relationship. The houses we finally ended up giving away, the equity in them. I did not care. Who cares? I have entered into a love relationship, and God gives me things just because He likes me. He loves me.

When I started coming across familiar verses that I had preached and quoted so many times, and when I learned these laws of meditation, I said, "God, what is the content? You said we would receive a hundredfold. I want to know what You mean, because it seems to be so hidden."

Do you know what He said to me? By then I already knew meditation. Before, He would say, "When are you going to quit taking the verse out of context?" and I would say, "How about now?"

But this time He said, "You are violating your own laws of meditation. I did not finish My message here. If you will go on, I will show you why you can count on two hands the men who have been there."

Addiction set in. "Go on? You mean to chapter 20? I thought You changed the subject. You mean go on?"

Addiction set in, and from that day to this He has eradicated the sense of lack on the inside of me. I am wallowing in His grace.

He did not change the subject.

Now, why are you reading now? If you do not read your Bibles this much at home, then it is impolite to read when somebody is talking to you. Do you want to get rich before we get to the end of the message or what?

I said, "How about now? I will quit violating my own laws. What do You want to show me?"

Even the very next verse. Look at verse 30:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

The poor interpreters of the King James did not know what to do with that verse. They did not know whether to put it as the first verse in chapter 20 or the thirtieth verse in chapter 19. They decided to leave it at the end of 19 because they did not know what it meant, and neither do most preachers I know.

Do you know how we use this verse? "The first will be last, and the last will be first" when we are late for dinner. That is okay, but after I found out what it meant, I felt like slapping them.

Let me show you. Go to Matthew 20:16:

So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

Did He change the subject? No. Then every verse between Matthew 19:30 and Matthew 20:16 is a stroke of the brush, still working on the same picture: why one man prospers and one does not.

What do you mean we have to cover the verses in between? Yes. I want to find out why you can count on two hands the men operating in that hundredfold.

In Matthew 19:30 He says:

But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.

Then all of a sudden He says:

For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder...

Stop. What is a parable? A parable is something I can understand with my natural mind that illustrates a spiritual application.

What spiritual application is He going to illustrate? No man who has left houses, lands, father, or mother will fail to receive a hundredfold. In answer to Peter's question, "We have left everything. What do we get out of it?" Jesus says, "No man who has forsaken houses and family will fail to receive a hundredfold."

Then He went on to explain why we are going to get a hundredfold, but He does it in parable form.

For the kingdom of heaven is like...

When we find out what He is comparing the kingdom of God to, then you and I can find out why we are going to get a hundredfold.

For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which went out early in the morning to hire labourers into his vineyard.

In light of the fact that He is breaking down a spiritual truth using a parable, who in the world is the householder? The householder is the Lord Jesus Christ. What is the vineyard? The kingdom of God. Who are the laborers? You and me.

If He is going to give Jesus' position, the kingdom of God that we labor in for the world's position, and our position as the steward, then when He gives all of our roles, it would behoove us to know the answer in the Spirit.

I am getting excited.

The kingdom of heaven is like a man who was a householder, who went out early in the morning to hire laborers, you and me, into His vineyard. What do laborers do? Work.

So we are going to find out whether it is works or whether it is grace.

Verse 2:

And when he had agreed with the labourers for a penny a day, he sent them into his vineyard.

And he went out about the third hour, and saw others standing idle in the marketplace, And said unto them; Go ye also into the vineyard, and whatsoever is right I will give you. And they went their way.

Again he went out about the sixth and ninth hour, and did likewise.

And about the eleventh hour he went out, and found others standing idle, and saith unto them, Why stand ye here all the day idle?

They say unto him, Because no man hath hired us. He saith unto them, Go ye also into the vineyard; and whatsoever is right, that shall ye receive.

You have one hour to work. One hour. Others had twelve hours; you have one hour.

So when even was come, the lord of the vineyard saith unto his steward, Call the labourers, and give them their hire, beginning from the last unto the first.

And when they came that were hired about the eleventh hour, they received every man a penny.

But when the first came, they supposed that they should have received more; and they likewise received every man a penny.

And when they had received it, they murmured against the goodman of the house,

Saying, These last have wrought but one hour, and thou hast made them equal unto us, which have borne the burden and heat of the day.

These last ones worked only one hour, and You, the Lord, made them equal with us, paying them the same as us. We have borne the burden and the heat of the day. We swept the church. We painted it. We put in nineteen hours a day, and nobody else did anything. I have arthritis and a blind eye, and that person did nothing, nothing except watch us work. When Roberson came, their deaf ear opened and their blind eye opened. I was faithful. I worked 763 hours on the building, and I am still blind and I still have arthritis. If anybody deserved it, it was me, Jesus.

What are you mad at Me for? Because I have made him equal with you?

The pay scale is not based on whether you worked one hour or twelve. It is based on faith in Jesus Christ and His grace, which made you and me equal with one another. It is not based on how long you worked, but faith in your God.

God, what could we learn if we ever learned how to meditate?